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California Becomes First State to Ban Four Chemicals in Food

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Food and Drink Additives Linked to Health Issues

California Governor Gavin Newsom has signed a bill into law that bans four food additives linked to health problems. This historic decision marks the first time a state has taken action to outlaw chemicals that are permitted by the Food and Drug Administration (FDA).

The prohibited additives include red dye No. 3, potassium bromate, brominated vegetable oil, and propylparaben.

These chemicals, already banned in the European Union and other parts of the world, can still be found in various commonly sold food items in the United States, such as certain brands of orange soda, icing, hamburger rolls, candies, and processed foods. They have been associated with issues ranging from hyperactivity in children to cancer.

Assembly Bill 418, introduced by Assemblymembers Jesse Gabriel and Buffy Wicks, both Democrats, will go into effect in 2027. The legislation does not result in the banning of any specific food products but instead requires food companies to make minor modifications using alternative ingredients already used overseas.

Environmental advocates such as the Environmental Working Group, which supported the bill, anticipate that the statewide ban will have nationwide implications for the food and beverage industry. Manufacturers are unlikely to create separate versions of their products solely for California, and therefore, ingredient lists for as many as 12,000 products sold nationwide may be adjusted.

Red dye No. 3, derived from petroleum, has already been banned by the FDA from cosmetics due to its cancer-causing properties in lab animals. Nonetheless, it is still used as an artificial color in food and medicine to achieve a bright red hue. Some studies also indicate a potential link between artificial food dyes and behavioral problems in children, although the FDA maintains there is no evidence of a causal relationship in the general population.

Other banned additives include potassium bromate, a flour additive tied to cancer in lab animals, and brominated vegetable oil, an emulsifier in citrus drinks associated with behavioral and reproductive issues in lab animals. Propylparaben, found in both cosmetics and food as a preservative, is believed to mimic estrogen and can act as an endocrine disruptor.

Governor Newsom's decision to delay the implementation of the law until 2027 is intended to provide companies with ample time to reformulate their recipes. Newsom emphasized the importance of the FDA establishing updated safety levels for these additives nationwide.

The California law has faced criticism from the National Confectioners Association, a trade group representing candy manufacturers, who argue that it will undermine consumer confidence and create inconsistency in food safety regulations.

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